



Senate

General Assembly

File No. 452

February Session, 2026

Substitute Senate Bill No. 235

Senate, April 7, 2026

The Committee on Transportation reported through SEN. COHEN of the 12th Dist., Chairperson of the Committee on the part of the Senate, that the substitute bill ought to pass.

AN ACT CONCERNING DRIVER EDUCATION AND STUDENT SAFETY.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Assembly convened:

1 Section 1. Section 14-78 of the general statutes is repealed and the
2 following is substituted in lieu thereof (*Effective October 1, 2026*):

3 (a) A drivers' school licensee shall permit a student to request that
4 such student's instructor be of a certain gender at the time of enrolling
5 in such licensee's behind-the-wheel instruction of a driver education
6 program and if such licensee cannot accommodate such request at the
7 time of any such instruction, such licensee shall allow the student to
8 reschedule such instruction without charging such student an
9 additional fee or penalty.

10 (b) Not later than January 1, 2027, if a driver's school licensee
11 maintains an Internet web site for its business, a drivers' school licensee
12 shall prominently post on such web site information indicating whether
13 or not such licensee has undertaken the following safety measures: (1)

14 The instructors employed by such licensee have successfully completed
15 proficiency testing as administered by the Department of Motor
16 Vehicles, (2) such instructors receive annual training or continuing
17 education, (3) such licensee utilizes an electronical monitoring system,
18 such as a global positioning system, to ensure the location of a student
19 is ascertainable during the provision of any behind-the-wheel
20 instruction, (4) such licensee utilizes an audio or video monitoring
21 system, such as a dashboard camera, inside or outside the motor vehicle
22 to ensure the safety of a student during the provision of any such
23 instruction, and (5) the vehicles used by such licensee to provide such
24 instruction have passed the annual inspection by the Department of
25 Motor Vehicles.

26 (c) The commissioner may adopt regulations, in accordance with the
27 provisions of chapter 54, regarding the conduct of drivers' schools and
28 instructor license requirements. Such regulations shall (1) establish the
29 conduct of drivers' schools, including, but not limited to, (A)
30 requirements as to the inspection of the vehicles used by the drivers'
31 schools in the conduct of their business, (B) instructional standards and
32 procedures, including instruction of not less than fifteen minutes
33 concerning the responsibilities of an operator of a motor vehicle under
34 subsection (b) of section 14-223 and the penalty for a violation of the
35 provisions of said subsection, instruction concerning highway work
36 zone safety and the responsibilities of an operator of a motor vehicle
37 under section 14-212d, [and] instruction concerning ways to reduce
38 incidents of operators driving in the wrong direction and actions to take
39 when an operator encounters a motor vehicle being operated in the
40 wrong direction and behind-the-wheel instruction and practice
41 concerning how to stop in a safe location off the traveled portion of the
42 highway and respond to a traffic stop by a law enforcement officer, (C)
43 the administration of a test at the conclusion of each class, (D) the
44 posting of rates charged for instruction, and (E) the general form in
45 which records concerning persons under instruction and those who
46 have completed their course of instruction shall be kept and, when
47 required, the method of transmission to the commissioner, (2) except as
48 required pursuant to section 14-36j, permit a class or classroom

49 instruction to be offered in person in a congregate setting, through
50 distance learning or through a combination of both in-person and
51 distance learning, provided such distance learning has interactive
52 components such as mandatory interactions, participation or testing,
53 and (3) establish the requirements for a person to receive a license as an
54 instructor in accordance with section 14-73.

55 (d) On and after October 1, 2010, the commissioner shall not issue a
56 license that is limited to classroom instruction. Any person who was
57 issued such limited license prior to October 1, 2010, may maintain and
58 renew such license.

59 Sec. 2. Section 14-36f of the general statutes is repealed and the
60 following is substituted in lieu thereof (*Effective October 1, 2026*):

61 The Commissioner of Motor Vehicles shall adopt regulations, in
62 accordance with the provisions of chapter 54, governing the
63 establishment, conduct and scope of driver education programs in
64 secondary schools of this state, subject to the requirements of section 14-
65 36e. Such regulations shall (1) permit any local or regional board of
66 education or private secondary school to contract with a licensed
67 drivers' school approved by the Commissioner of Motor Vehicles for the
68 behind-the-wheel instruction of such driver education program and
69 instruction therein may be given by such school's driving instructors
70 who are licensed by the Department of Motor Vehicles, (2) require that
71 the classroom instruction of any such driver education program include
72 (A) a discussion concerning highway work zone safety and the
73 responsibilities of an operator of a motor vehicle under section 14-212d,
74 and (B) a discussion concerning ways to reduce incidents of operators
75 driving in the wrong direction and actions to take when an operator
76 encounters a motor vehicle being operated in the wrong direction, [and]
77 (3) except for instruction offered pursuant to section 14-36j, permit a
78 class or classroom instruction to be offered in person in a congregate
79 setting, through distance learning or through a combination of both in-
80 person and distance learning, provided such distance learning has
81 interactive components such as mandatory interactions, participation or

82 testing, and (4) require that the behind-the-wheel instruction of any such
 83 driver education program include instruction and practice regarding
 84 how to stop in a safe location off the traveled portion of the highway
 85 and respond to a traffic stop by a law enforcement officer.

This act shall take effect as follows and shall amend the following sections:

Section 1	October 1, 2026	14-78
Sec. 2	October 1, 2026	14-36f

Statement of Legislative Commissioners:

In Section 1(a), "the gender of such student's instructor" was changed to "that such student's instructor be of a certain gender" for clarity, in Section 1(b), "concerning various safety measures undertaken by such licensee. Such safety measures shall include, but need not be limited to, whether" was changed to "indicating whether or not such licensee has undertaken the following safety measures:" for clarity, in Section 1(b)(1), "department" was changed to "Department of Motor Vehicles" for clarity, in Section 1(b)(3), "such" was changed to "behind-the-wheel" for consistency, and in Section 1(b)(5), "on-the-road" was changed to "such" for consistency.

TRA *Joint Favorable Subst.*

The following Fiscal Impact Statement and Bill Analysis are prepared for the benefit of the members of the General Assembly, solely for purposes of information, summarization and explanation and do not represent the intent of the General Assembly or either chamber thereof for any purpose. In general, fiscal impacts are based upon a variety of informational sources, including the analyst's professional knowledge. Whenever applicable, agency data is consulted as part of the analysis, however final products do not necessarily reflect an assessment from any specific department.

OFA Fiscal Note

State Impact:

Agency Affected	Fund-Effect	FY 27 \$	FY 28 \$
Motor Vehicle Dept.	TF - Potential Revenue Gain	Minimal	Minimal

Note: TF=Transportation Fund

Municipal Impact: None

Explanation

The bill changes the requirements that driving schools must meet, resulting in potential minimal revenue gain from any new penalties imposed. Under existing law, the Department of Motor Vehicles may impose a civil penalty of up to \$1,000 for driving school violations.

The Out Years

The annualized ongoing fiscal impact identified above would continue into the future subject to the number of violations.

OLR Bill Analysis**sSB 235****AN ACT CONCERNING DRIVER EDUCATION AND STUDENT SAFETY.****SUMMARY**

The bill makes several changes related to driving schools, driver's education programs, and behind-the-wheel training.

The bill requires commercial driving schools to allow students to request an instructor of a certain gender when they enroll in the behind-the-wheel instruction component of a driver education program. If the driving school cannot accommodate a student's request at any time during the instruction, it must allow the student to reschedule without charging an additional fee or penalty.

Under the bill, commercial driving schools must, by January 1, 2027, prominently post on their websites (if they have one) information on whether or not the school has implemented these safety measures:

1. their instructors have completed Department of Motor Vehicles (DMV)-administered proficiency testing;
2. their instructors receive annual training or continuing education;
3. the school uses electronic monitoring systems, such as GPS, to track a student's location during behind-the-wheel instruction;
4. the school uses an audio or video monitoring system, such as a dash camera, inside or outside of the vehicle to ensure a student's safety; and
5. the vehicles the school uses for behind-the-wheel instruction are annually inspected by DMV.

Lastly, the bill specifies that the behind-the-wheel instruction component of a driver's education program must include practicing how to pull off the road in a safe location and respond to a police officer's traffic stop. This requirement applies to driver's education programs offered by commercial driving schools, local or regional boards of education, or private secondary schools.

EFFECTIVE DATE: October 1, 2026

COMMITTEE ACTION

Transportation Committee

Joint Favorable Substitute

Yea 36 Nay 0 (03/16/2026)